

selling it to a music firm. They, in turn, sold it to his German publisher, who issued it in multiple arrangements: Valse triste was soon being played by hotel and salon bands all over Europe. Sibelius never quite forgave himself for missing out on a small fortune in royalty payments. His next major works were a virtuosic Violin Concerto and a Third Symphony in a leaner, more Classical style and with a quietly introspective poetic streak. In 1903, Sibelius took out a loan to build a family home in the village of Järvenpää, near Lake Tuusula, north of Helsinki. He financed the construction of “Ainola” (Aino’s Home) with help from his annual stipend from the Finnish government (first granted in 1897) and his erratic earnings from music. The family moved into their new home in 1904.

Four years later, however, Sibelius was diagnosed with throat cancer. Painful surgery in Berlin proved successful, but the experience influenced the dark, austere mood of his Fourth Symphony in 1911.